雅思口语题库 2026 年 9-12 月

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Part 1·日常话题

唱歌 Singing

01 Did you sing when you were a child?

Yes, quite a lot actually. I was in the school choir for two years, so I sang almost every week. Most of the songs were simple children's songs, and I really enjoyed them. I wasn't the best singer, but I never felt shy about it back then.

有的，唱得还挺多。我参加过两年学校合唱团，基本上每周都要唱。唱的多半是简单的儿歌，我当时特别喜欢。我唱得不算好，但那时候一点也不怯场。

02 How well did you sing?

To be honest, not very well. I could follow the melody, but my voice always went flat when the song got high. My music teacher was kind about it, though, and said I just needed more practice. Looking back, I think I enjoyed singing more than I was actually good at it.

说实话，唱得不怎么样。旋律我跟得上，可一到高音就跑调。不过音乐老师挺宽容，她说我只是练得太少。现在回想，我唱歌更多是因为喜欢，而不是唱得好。

03 Do you like singing?

I do, but only when I'm on my own. I sing along to whatever is playing in my headphones, usually while I'm doing chores or walking somewhere. I'd never sing in front of other people because I'd feel far too self-conscious.

喜欢，但只在我一个人的时候。我一般戴着耳机跟着歌一起唱，多半是干家务或者走路的时候。我绝不会在别人面前唱，太放不开了。

04 Did you take music lessons?

I had piano lessons for about two years when I was in primary school. It was my mum's idea rather than mine, and I have to admit I didn't practise as much as I should have. I can still read simple sheet music, but I've forgotten most of what I learned.

小学时我学过两年钢琴。那是我妈的主意，不是我自己想学的，说实话我练得远远不够。现在简单的谱子我还能看，但学过的东西大半都忘了。

05 Will you sing in the car?

Definitely. When I'm driving by myself, the radio goes up and I sing along without even thinking about it. It makes long journeys pass much faster. But the moment there's a passenger in the car, I stop, because I'd be too embarrassed.

肯定会。我一个人开车的时候，会把收音机音量调大，不自觉地跟着

唱，长途路上时间过得快多了。但只要车上有别人，我立刻就停，太尴尬了。

整洁 Tidiness

01 Were you a tidy person as a child?

Not really. My room was usually a mess, and I only tidied it up when my parents told me to. I knew exactly where everything was, though, so the mess never bothered me. My mum found that hard to believe.

不太算。我的房间经常乱糟糟的，只有爸妈说了我才会收拾。不过什么东西在哪儿我心里都有数，所以乱我也无所谓。我妈对此完全不能理解。

02 Are you a tidy person now?

Much tidier than I used to be. I started keeping things in order after I moved into my own flat, mainly because I have to share the space with someone else. Now I actually find tidying quite relaxing, which surprises me.

比以前整洁多了。自己搬出来住之后我开始收拾东西，主要是因为要和别人共用空间。现在我居然觉得整理挺解压的，连我自己都意外。

03 What do you think of untidy people?

I try not to judge them, because being messy is rarely a moral failing.

Some people simply have other priorities, or they work better in a bit of chaos. That said, I do think untidiness becomes a problem when it affects the people you live with.

我尽量不去评判，因为乱一点大多扯不上人品问题。有些人只是有更要紧的事，或者乱着反而更顺手。不过我个人觉得，如果乱到影响同住的人，那就是问题了。

04 What do you think of those who don't care about tidiness?

I can understand it up to a point. If someone lives alone, then how they keep their home is entirely their own business. But when you share a kitchen or a bathroom with other people, a basic level of tidiness becomes a form of consideration rather than a personal choice.

某种程度上我能理解。如果一个人独居，那家里怎么弄完全是他自己的事。但一旦要和别人共用厨房或卫生间，基本的整洁就不只是个人选择了，而是一种体谅。

科学 **Science**

01 Did you learn much about science at school?

Quite a bit, yes. Science was compulsory until I was about fifteen, so I studied biology, chemistry and physics. I remember enjoying the practical lessons far more than the theory, because we got to do

experiments and see things happen for ourselves.

学了不少。十五岁之前科学是必修的，生物、化学、物理都学过。我记得比起理论，我更喜欢实验课，因为能自己动手，亲眼看到结果。

02 How do you learn about science in daily life?

Mostly through short videos and podcasts. I follow a few channels that explain things like why the sky changes colour, or how vaccines work, in plain language. I also pick things up from news articles, especially anything about space or medical research.

主要靠短视频和播客。我关注了几个账号，会把「天为什么变色」「疫苗怎么起作用」这类问题讲得很通俗。另外我也会从新闻里学到一些，尤其是太空和医学研究方面的。

03 Do you like science?

I do, though more as an interested outsider than as a specialist. What appeals to me is the way science gives you a method for testing your own assumptions instead of just guessing. I'm not good at maths, so I'd never have studied it seriously.

喜欢，不过我算是个感兴趣的门外汉，不是专业人士。吸引我的是科学给人一套验证自己想法的办法，而不是凭感觉猜。我数学不好，所以肯定不会去正经学理科。

04 What area of science do you know about?

Probably biology, since it was my favourite subject at school. I know the basics of how cells work, how genes are passed on, and how the human body fights infections. I've also read a fair amount about nutrition, which is a practical side of the same subject.

大概是生物，因为那是我上学时最喜欢的科目。细胞怎么运作、基因怎么遗传、人体如何抵抗感染，这些基础我还记得。另外我读过不少营养学的东西，算是同一领域里比较实用的部分。

手表 Watch

01 Do you wear a watch in your daily life?

Hardly ever now, I'm afraid. I used to wear one every day, but once I started carrying a phone everywhere I stopped bothering. The only time I put a watch on is when I'm going somewhere formal and want to look a bit more put together.

现在几乎不戴了。我以前天天戴，但后来手机不离身，就懒得再戴了。唯一戴的时候是去正式场合，想让自己看起来体面一点。

02 Has anyone ever given you a watch?

Yes, my parents gave me one when I turned eighteen. It was a simple silver one, nothing expensive, but it came in a proper box with a note inside. I still keep it even though the battery has long since died.

有，我十八岁生日时父母送过一块。很朴素的银色款，不贵，但装在一个正经的表盒里，里面还放了张字条。虽然电池早就不走了，我还一直留着。

03 Do people around you like wearing watches?

It varies a lot. Most of my friends have given up on them and just check their phones. The ones who still wear watches tend to fall into two groups: people who need to check the time constantly at work, and people who treat a watch as a piece of jewellery.

差别挺大的。我大部分朋友都不戴了，看时间直接看手机。还在戴的基本分两类：一类是工作中需要频繁看时间的，另一类是把表当饰品戴的。

04 What kind of watches do they usually like?

From what I've noticed, younger people prefer smart watches, mainly for tracking steps and sleep rather than for telling the time. Older people I know tend to go for classic mechanical ones with leather straps, which they see as something worth keeping for years.

我观察下来，年轻人更喜欢智能手表，主要用来记步数和睡眠，看时间反而次要。我认识的长辈则偏好经典机械表，配皮表带，他们觉得这种东西值得戴很多年。

公园与花园 **Park and gardens**

01 Was there a park near your home that you liked to go to when you were a child?

Yes, there was a small one about ten minutes' walk from our flat. It had a slide, a few swings and a pond with ducks in it. It wasn't anything special, but for me as a child it felt like a proper adventure every time we went.

有，离我们家走路大概十分钟。公园不大，有滑梯、几个秋千，还有个能看鸭子的池塘。其实没什么特别的，但小时候每次去我都觉得像探险一样。

02 What did you do there?

Mainly running around and feeding the ducks with my dad, who took me most weekends. There was also a small ice cream stand near the gate, so the trip usually ended with one. In summer the park was packed with families doing more or less the same thing.

主要是我爸带着我到处跑、喂鸭子，基本上每个周末都去。公园门口有个卖冰淇淋的小摊，所以每次都是吃着冰淇淋回家。夏天公园里全是家庭，大家干的事都差不多。

03 Do you think there should be more parks and gardens in your city?

Very much so. The area I live in is almost entirely concrete, and the

nearest green space is a twenty- minute bus ride away. I think small parks on every few streets would do more good than one large one on the edge of the city, simply because people would actually use them. 非常应该。我住的那一片几乎全是水泥，最近的绿地要坐二十分钟公交。我觉得每隔几条街就有个小公园，比在城郊建一个大的更有用，因为大家真的会去。

网站 **Websites**

01 Do you like using websites?

Yes, I spend a fair amount of time on them, mostly for studying and for finding things out. What I like is that you can dig as deep as you want, and there's usually someone out there who has already answered your question. The downside is how easily you get pulled off track.中文喜欢，我在网站上花的时间不少，主要是学习和查资料。我喜欢的是你想挖多深就能挖多深，而且通常你想要的那个答案早有人写过了。坏处是特别容易跑偏。

02 Do you prefer searching for information on websites or in books?

It depends on what I'm looking for. For anything current, or for a quick fact, websites are unbeatable. But if I want to properly understand a subject, I'd rather read a book, because the argument is laid out from beginning to end instead of arriving in fragments.

看我要找什么。如果是时事或者查个小事实，网站无可替代。但如果我想真正弄懂一个主题，我更愿意看书，因为书的论述是从头到尾铺开的，而不是碎片式地砸过来。

03 Do you plan to create your own website?

I've thought about it, but I doubt I'd ever get round to it. I'd love a small site where I could keep my notes and things I've written, purely for myself. The problem is that I'd spend weeks choosing a layout and never actually write anything.

想过，但估计我永远不会真去做。我挺想要个小网站，把我的笔记和写过的东西放上去，纯粹是给自己看。问题在于我会花好几个星期挑版式，最后什么都没写。

04 Which website do you usually use?

Probably a video site called Bilibili, and I use it far more than I'd like to admit. I go there for lectures, documentaries and study channels, although I often end up watching something completely unrelated. Apart from that, I use a dictionary site and a news site every day.

应该是 **B** 站，用的时间比我愿意承认的还多。我上去看讲座、纪录片和学习类频道，不过经常一不留神就看起完全无关的东西。除此之外，我每天还会用一个词典网站和一个新闻网站。

太空 **The space**

01 Have you ever learnt anything about space and the stars when you were at school?

A little, mostly in geography and physics lessons. We covered the solar system, the phases of the moon and why we have seasons. I remember being far more interested in the pictures than in the calculations, which probably says something about me.

学得不多，主要是在地理和物理课里。我们讲过太阳系、月相，还有为什么会有四季。我记得当时对图片的兴趣远远大于对计算的兴趣，这大概也说明了点什么。

02 Would you like to know more about space and the stars?

I would, yes, though I suspect my interest is fairly shallow. I enjoy reading about new discoveries and looking at images from telescopes, but I've never felt the urge to learn the underlying physics. For me it's closer to wonder than to study.

想，不过我怀疑我的兴趣挺浅的。我喜欢看新发现的消息和望远镜拍的照片，但从没想过要去弄懂背后的物理。对我来说这更接近好奇心，而不是研究。

03 Do you like science-fiction movies set in space?

Some of them, especially the ones that stay reasonably close to real

science. What puts me off is when a film uses space purely as a backdrop for explosions and the science makes no sense at all. I'd much rather watch something slow and thoughtful.

有些喜欢，尤其是那些跟真实科学还比较接近的。我不太受得了那种只把太空当背景、拿来放爆炸场面、科学完全说不通的片子。我更愿意看节奏慢一点、有点想法的。

04 Do you want to go into outer space in the future?

Honestly, no. The idea of it sounds romantic, but I think the reality would be cramped, uncomfortable and quite frightening. I'd rather keep my feet on the ground and enjoy other people's photographs, which seems like a much better deal.

说实话，不想。这事想起来挺浪漫，但真去了恐怕又挤又难受，还挺吓人。我还是愿意脚踏实地，看别人拍回来的照片，这买卖划算得。

音乐 **Music**

01 Do you like music?

I'd say music is one of the few things I genuinely couldn't do without. I have something playing almost all day, and it changes how I feel about whatever I'm doing. Even a dull task becomes bearable if the right song is on.

音乐大概是我少数几样真的离不开的东西之一。我几乎整天都在放，

它会影响我做任何事时的心情。只要放对了歌，再无聊的活儿也能忍。

02 What kinds of music do you listen to?

Mostly folk and acoustic singer-songwriter stuff. I like songs where you can hear the words clearly and the arrangement doesn't get in the way. When I need to concentrate I switch to instrumental piano, since lyrics distract me from reading.

主要是民谣和原声创作歌手那一类。我喜欢能听清歌词、编曲不抢戏的歌。需要专心的时候我会换成纯钢琴，因为有歌词我就读不进去书。

03 Do you prefer sad or happy music?

That depends on my mood rather than on any real preference. If I'm already low, a sad song somehow makes me feel better understood, though I know that sounds odd. When I'm in a good mood I want something with energy in it.

这更多取决于我当下的心情，而不是我有什么固定偏好。如果我已经情绪低落，听伤感的歌反而让我觉得被理解了，虽然这话听着有点怪。心情好的时候我就想听有劲儿的。

04 Does happy music make you feel more excited?

It does, especially if it has a fast tempo and a strong beat. I sometimes put on something lively before I have to do something difficult,

almost like a warm- up. It doesn't change the task, but it does change how willing I am to start it.

会，尤其是节奏快、鼓点强的。遇到难办的事之前，我会先放点欢快的歌，有点像热身。事情本身没变，但我愿意动手的程度变了。

05 Is it easy to learn music?

I'd say it's easy to start and hard to continue. Almost anyone can pick out a tune on a keyboard within an afternoon, but getting properly good takes years of repetitive practice that most people give up on. So I'd call it easy to begin, but not easy to learn.

我觉得入门容易，坚持下去难。几乎谁都能用一个下午在键盘上弹出个调子，但要真的弹好，得练上好几年枯燥的基本功，多数人撑不到那时候。所以我说它是开始容易、学会不易。

06 Do you learn music lessons at school?

We had music as a compulsory subject until about fourteen, once a week. It was mostly singing together and learning basic notation, and I don't think anyone took it very seriously. Anything beyond that was an optional club, which I never joined.

十四岁之前音乐是必修，每周一节。内容主要是合唱和学点基础乐理，我觉得大家都没太当回事。再往深的就是选修社团了，我从没报过。

老师 Teachers

01 Is it easy to remember your teachers in elementary school?

Surprisingly easy, yes. I can still picture several of them and even imitate the way they spoke. I think it's because we spent six years in the same room with the same faces, and at that age a teacher is a much bigger presence than they are later on.

意外地容易。有几位老师的模样我现在还能想起来，连他们说话的腔调都学得来。我觉得是因为那六年都在同一个教室、同一批人，而且那个年纪老师给人的分量比后来重得多。

02 Did you want to be a teacher when you were young?

For a short while, mainly because I liked the idea of writing on the blackboard. It didn't last long, though. Once I realised how much preparation goes on outside the classroom, and how much patience it takes, I lost interest fairly quickly.

有过一阵子，主要是觉得能在黑板上写字很酷。但没持续多久。等我明白课堂之外要备多少课、需要多大耐心之后，我很快就没兴趣了。

03 Do you think teachers are different now than when your parents were at school?

Very different, I'd say. My parents describe teachers who were strict and whose word was final, and who taught mainly by lecturing. Now

teachers seem to spend much more time on discussion, group work and dealing with students' individual problems, which is a heavier job in some ways.

差别很大。我父母描述的是一群很严厉、说一不二、主要靠讲授的老师。现在的老师花在讨论、小组活动和处理学生个人问题上的时间多得多，某种程度上这活儿更累。

04 Did you have a favorite teacher at school?

Yes, my English teacher in my last two years. What made her different was that she asked for our opinions instead of just checking whether we'd memorised the textbook. She also remembered small details about all of us, which at that age meant a great deal.

有，最后两年的英语老师。她不一样的地方在于，她会问我们的看法，而不只是检查有没有背下课本。她还记得我们每个人的小事，那个年纪这点特别重要。

社交媒体 **Social media**

01 Do your friends and family use social media?

Almost all of them, to different degrees. My friends use it constantly and treat it as their main way of staying in touch. My parents are on it too, though mainly to follow relatives and to share things they've cooked.

基本上都用，程度不一样。我朋友用得很多，把它当成主要联系方式。我爸妈也上，不过主要是关注亲戚、晒自己做的菜。

02 Do you think people in your country find social media useful?

Clearly yes, given how much time people spend on it. It's genuinely useful for keeping in touch and for getting information quickly, especially for small businesses selling directly to customers. That said, usefulness and healthy use aren't the same thing.

显然觉得有用，看大家花在上面的时间就知道了。它确实方便联络、获取信息也快，对直接卖货的小商家尤其有用。不过有用和健康地使用，不是一回事。

03 Do you spend too much time on social media?

More than I'd like, yes. I've started checking my screen time every week and the number is always higher than I expect. The strange part is that I rarely feel better afterwards, even when I've enjoyed scrolling, so it's not really a fair exchange.

比我愿意承认的多。我现在每周都会看使用时长统计，每次都比我以为的高。奇怪的是刷完之后我很少觉得更舒服，即使当下挺乐在其中，所以这买卖其实不划算。

04 When did you start using social media?

Around the age of fifteen, when most of my classmates joined at roughly the same time. Before that I only used messaging apps. Looking back, the first thing I did on it was compare myself with other people, which wasn't a great start.

大概十五岁，那时候班上同学基本是同一时间开始用的。在那之前我只用聊天软件。回头看，我上去干的第一件事就是拿自己和别人比，这个开头可不太好。

耳机 Headphone

01 How often do you wear headphones?

Almost every day, usually for a couple of hours at a time. I put them on when I'm commuting, when I'm studying, and sometimes just to signal to the people around me that I'd rather not be interrupted.

几乎每天都戴，一般一次两三个小时。通勤的时候戴，学习的时候戴，有时候纯粹是想给周围的人一个信号：别来打扰我。

02 Do you think headphones are useful?

Extremely, and not only for listening to things. In a shared flat or on a crowded train they let you create a bit of private space, which is hard to get any other way. I'd say they've quietly changed how people behave in public.

非常有用，而且不只是用来听东西。在合租房或者拥挤的地铁里，耳

机能给你造出一小块私人空间，别的办法很难做到。我觉得它悄悄改变了人们在公共场合的行为方式。

03 Are headphones popular in your country?

Enormously. Walk into any carriage on the underground and you'll see almost everyone wearing a pair. The wireless ones in particular have become a kind of everyday accessory, and people now care about how they look as much as how they sound.

特别普及。随便走进一节地铁车厢，几乎人人一副。尤其无线耳机已经变成日常配饰了，现在大家在意好不好看不亚于在意好不好听。

04 In what situations should people not wear headphones?

When they need to be aware of what's going on around them, mainly. Cycling on a busy road with both ears covered strikes me as genuinely dangerous, and I'd say the same about crossing a road. In a hospital or a doctor's waiting room I'd also take them off, out of simple courtesy.

主要是在需要感知周围情况的时候。骑车走繁忙路段还两只耳朵都堵着，我觉得是真危险，过马路也一样。在医院或者候诊室里，出于基本的礼貌我也会摘掉。

讲笑话 **Telling Jokes**

01 Do you like to tell jokes?

I enjoy it, but I'm not especially good at it. I can never remember the wording exactly, so by the time I get to the punchline I've usually added too much detail and killed it. My friends have learned to be patient with me.

我挺喜欢的，但不太擅长。我总记不住原话，讲到包袱的时候往往已经加了太多细节，活活讲死了。我朋友都学会对我有耐心了。

02 Do you often joke with your friends?

Constantly, in a very low-key way. Most of it isn't proper jokes so much as teasing each other about small things. I think that kind of easy back-and-forth says more about how close a friendship is than any serious conversation does.

经常，不过都是很随意的。大多算不上正经笑话，就是拿小事互相逗。我觉得这种轻松的来回，比任何严肃的谈心都更能说明关系近不近。

03 Do you have friends who love telling jokes?

One in particular, and he tells the same handful of jokes over and over. Oddly, they get funnier each time because we all know exactly what's coming. He also has a habit of laughing at his own punchline before he reaches it.

有一个特别典型，而且他会把同样的几个笑话反复讲。奇怪的是每次

我们都更想笑，因为完全知道他要说什么。他还有个毛病，包袱还没抖出来自己就先笑了。

04 What are some common comedy shows in your country?

Stand- up has become very popular in the last few years, and there are several televised competitions where new comedians get discovered. Alongside that, the sketch shows and talk shows on television have had a big audience for a long time and still do.

这几年脱口秀特别火，还有好几档电视比赛专门挖掘新人。除此之外，电视上的小品和谈话类节目也一直有很稳定的观众群，到现在还是。

05 Do you like being joked about?

It depends entirely on who's doing it and why. Among close friends I don't mind at all, and I'd probably join in. But when the teasing comes from someone I barely know, or when it's aimed at something I'm actually sensitive about, it stops being funny very fast.

完全看是谁、出于什么目的。好朋友之间我完全不介意，还会跟着一起自嘲。但如果是不太熟的人来开，或者拿我真正在意的事情说事，那很快就不好笑了。

汽车 Cars

01 Would you like to be the driver or the passenger?

Usually the passenger, if it's a long trip. I like being able to read or just watch the scenery go past, and I find other people's driving genuinely interesting to watch. On short local journeys, though, I'd rather drive myself so I can leave when I want to.

如果是长途，我一般愿意当乘客。我可以看书，或者就看着窗外发呆，而且看别人怎么开车挺有意思的。但短途的话我更愿意自己开，这样想什么时候走就什么时候走。

02 Are there a lot of cars on the roads in your city?

Far too many, especially during the rush hour. The main roads turn into a slow-moving queue for about two hours every morning and evening. That's one reason I take the underground whenever the journey allows it.

太多了，尤其是高峰期。主干道每天早上和傍晚各有两个小时基本就是慢慢往前挪。这也是我只要路线允许就坐地铁的原因之一。

03 Do you want to own a very expensive car？

Not really, no. I can see the appeal, but where I live a car is mostly a way of getting from one traffic jam to the next, and parking is a nightmare. I'd rather spend that money on travelling, which is what I'd actually enjoy.

不太想。我能理解那种吸引力，但在我住的地方，车基本就是从一段

堵车开到下一段堵车，停车还是场灾难。我更愿意把这笔钱花在旅行上，那才是我真正享受的。

04 Did you go on a long car journey when you were a child?

Every summer, yes. We drove about eight hours to my grandparents' place, and I remember the back seat feeling enormous at the start of the trip and unbearably cramped by the end. My parents still talk about how many times I asked whether we were nearly there.

每年夏天都去。我们开车大概八个小时去我祖父母家。我记得出发时后座感觉特别宽敞，到后面挤得受不了。我爸妈到现在还会说，我一路上问了多少遍「快到了吗」。

衣服 Clothes

01 What kind of clothes do you like to wear?

Simple, comfortable things, mostly in plain colours. I've gradually stopped buying anything that needs special care, so almost everything I own can go in the same wash. I'd rather have a few pieces I wear all the time than a wardrobe full of things I never touch.

简单、舒服的，基本是纯色的。我慢慢不买那些需要特别打理的衣物了，所以现在几乎所有的衣服都能扔一起洗。我宁可只有几件天天穿的，也不想有一柜子从来不碰的。

02 Do you wear different clothes on the weekend?

Much more casual, yes. During the week I have to look reasonably presentable, so it's shirts and proper trousers. At the weekend I'm almost always in a sweatshirt and trainers, and honestly I look forward to that all week.

会，周末随意得多。工作日得穿得像样点，衬衫加正装裤。周末我基本就是卫衣配运动鞋，说实话我整整一周都在盼这个。

03 Do you buy clothes because of the brand? What brands do you usually buy?

Not for the logo, but I do tend to stick to a few brands because I know how their sizes fit me. That saves an enormous amount of time when shopping online. If something from a brand I've never tried is cheaper and looks well made, I'm happy to take the risk.

不是为了那个标，但我确实会固定买几个牌子，因为我知道它们的尺码我穿多大。这样网购能省下大量时间。如果是一个我没试过的牌子，价格更便宜、看着做工也不错，我也乐意冒险。

04 What colors of clothes do you dislike?

Very bright shades, particularly neon yellow and orange, because they overwhelm everything else you're wearing and are hard to match. I'm not keen on pale pink either, since it tends to look washed

out on me. Dark navy and grey are what I reach for most.

特别亮的颜色，尤其是荧光黄和橙色，太抢眼了，跟什么都难搭。浅粉色我也不太喜欢，穿在我身上显得没精神。我最常穿的是深藏蓝和灰色。

购物 Shopping

01 Do you often go shopping?

Not for pleasure, but I shop for essentials most weeks. I've got into the habit of making a list before I go, which sounds dull but has cut down how much I waste. For anything bigger I tend to wait and think about it for a few days.

不是去逛着玩，但每周基本都要买生活必需品。我养成了出门前列清单的习惯，听着挺无聊，但确实少浪费了不少。买大件的话我会先搁几天再决定。

02 Do you prefer online or offline shopping?

Online for almost everything, mainly because I can compare prices without walking between five shops. That said, I still buy shoes in person, since sizes vary so much between brands that ordering them feels like a lottery.

几乎什么都网购，主要是能比价，不用在五家店之间来回走。不过鞋子我还是实体店买，因为不同牌子尺码差太多，下单基本靠运气。

03 Do you compare prices before making a purchase?

Always, even for small things. It takes about a minute now, and I've been surprised often enough to keep doing it. My rule is that if the difference is tiny I'll just buy from whoever I trust, but for anything expensive I'll check properly.

每次都比，哪怕是小东西。现在比价也就一分钟的事，而且我被惊到过太多次，所以一直坚持。我的原则是差得不多就找信得过的卖家买；但贵的东西我会认真比。

04 Have you ever returned a product you bought?

A few times, mostly clothes that didn't fit as expected. I used to feel awkward about it and would just keep things I didn't want. Now I've realised that returning an item is a normal part of shopping, and the process is usually much simpler than I feared.

退过几次，多数是衣服尺码不对。以前我会觉得不好意思，就把不想要的东西留下了。现在我想通了，退货本来就是购物的一部分，而且流程通常比我担心的简单得多。

Part 2 & Part 3·题卡

01 无聊的地方

Describe a boring place you have been to

You should say:

Where it is

When you went there

Who you went with

And explain why you felt it was boring

示范作答 The place I'd like to describe is a seaside resort my family took me to when I was about thirteen. It's on the east coast, roughly four hours away by coach, and it's the sort of town that fills up for two months a year and then goes quiet.We went during the summer holiday, and I was there with my parents and my younger cousin. My aunt had booked it, so none of us had much say in the choice. We stayed for five nights, which turned out to be about four too many.

What made it boring was that there was genuinely nothing to do beyond the beach. The sand was covered in litter and the water was too cold to swim in, so we mostly just sat there. The town itself had one main street with a couple of souvenir shops and fast food places, and everything shut before nine in the evening. By the third day we had already walked around it twice.

The evenings were the worst part. There was no cinema, no arcade, nothing that stays open late, so we ended up back in the hotel room watching television, which we could have done at home. My cousin and I played cards until we got bored of that too.

I think the real problem was that we had expected something lively, because the photographs online made it look far more exciting than it really was. It taught me to look past the marketing and read a few honest reviews before booking anything. I wouldn't say I hated it, but I have no wish to go back.

我想说的这个地方，是十三岁那年家里人带我去的海边小镇。它在东海岸，坐大巴大概四个小时，属于那种一年热闹两个月、剩下时间就冷清下来的地方。我们是暑假去的，同去的有我爸妈和我表弟。是我姑姑订的行程，我们谁都没什么发言权。总共住了五晚，事后看大概多住了四个晚上。

之所以无聊，是因为除了海滩真的没什么可做的。沙滩上到处是垃圾，海水又冷得没法下水，所以我们基本就是干坐着。镇上只有一条主街，几家纪念品店和快餐店，晚上九点前全关门了。到第三天我们已经把那条街来回走了两遍。

晚上是最难熬的。没有电影院，没有游戏厅，没有一样开到很晚的东西，最后只能回酒店房间看电视 —— 可这在家也能看。我和表弟打牌，打到连牌都腻了。

我觉得根本问题在于期待错了。网上的照片把它拍得比实际有意思得多。这件事教会我：订任何行程之前，别只看宣传，要去翻几条真实的评价。我倒不至于说讨厌那儿，但确实完全不想再去。

Part3 讨论题

01 On what occasions do people feel bored?

Usually when there's nothing to occupy them and no way to change that. Long waits are the classic case, whether it's a queue, a delayed flight or a meeting that drags on. I'd also add situations that are repetitive, because once you can predict exactly what happens next, your attention just drifts away.

通常是既没事可做、又没办法改变的时候。最典型的是漫长等待：排队、航班延误，或者一场拖得很长的会。我还会加上重复性的场合，因为一旦你能准确预测接下来会发生什么，注意力自然就飘走了。

02 Why do students find their teachers' lessons boring?

Often because the lesson is delivered in one direction only. If a teacher reads from the textbook or speaks at the same pace for forty minutes, there's nothing for the students to do but listen, and that's very hard to sustain. Lessons also feel dull when students can't see why the topic matters to them, since effort without a reason is difficult to justify.

往往是因为课只往一个方向走。如果老师照着课本念，或者用同一个语调讲四十分钟，学生除了听没别的事可做，这很难撑住。另外，当学生看不出这个内容跟自己有什么关系时，课也会显得无聊，因为没理由的努力是很难持续的。

03 How to avoid feeling bored?

It helps to give your attention something concrete to work on. If I'm stuck somewhere, I'll set myself a small task, like noticing five details about the place I'd never seen before, and that usually does the trick. Changing your surroundings even briefly also works, and so does having something to look forward to later in the day.

给注意力找个具体的着力点会有帮助。如果我被困在某个地方，我会给自己派个小任务，比如找出五个以前没注意过的细节，通常就管用了。换个环境、哪怕只是一小会儿也有用；另外，当天稍晚有点值得期待的事，同样有效。

04 Why do some people find playing on their phones boring?

I think it's because a lot of phone use is passive. Scrolling without a particular aim means you're consuming whatever appears rather than choosing it, and that quickly stops being satisfying. Nothing on a screen asks much of you either, so there's no sense of having achieved anything, and that feeling is usually what makes an activity seem

worthwhile.

我觉得是因为很多手机使用是被动的。没有目的地刷，意味着你只是在接收推过来的东西，而不是自己挑的，这种满足感很快就没了。另外，屏幕上的事对你几乎没有任何要求，所以不会产生「做成了什么」的感觉，而那种感觉通常才是一件事让人觉得值得做的原因。

02 高建筑

Describe a high- rise building you like or dislike

You should say:

Where it is

What it looks like

What it is used for

And explain why you like or dislike it

示范作答 **The high- rise I want to describe is Shanghai Tower, in the Lujiazui area of Pudong. It's one of the tallest buildings in the country, just over six hundred metres, and it's the one I always notice whenever I see a photograph of the Shanghai skyline.It's hard to miss because of its shape. Instead of going straight up, the whole tower twists as it rises, and the outside is wrapped in two layers of glass, which makes the surface look almost like a ribbon. During the day it reflects whatever the weather is doing, and after dark the lighting on it changes colour, so it looks different every time you pass it.**

As for what it's used for, it's a mixed-use building rather than just offices. The lower section holds shops and restaurants, the middle part is office space, and above that there's a hotel. Near the top there's an observation deck, which is what most visitors actually go for, since on a clear day you can see right across the river and well beyond it.

I'd say I like it, though more as a piece of design than as a place to spend time. What impresses me is that such a tall building manages to look elegant instead of bulky, which is not an easy thing to achieve. My only reservation is about what it represents, because buildings of that scale tend to be more about a city's ambitions than about the people living in it.

我想说的高楼是浦东陆家嘴的上海中心大厦。它是国内最高的建筑之一，六百多米，每次看到上海天际线的照片，我第一个注意到的就是它。它很难被忽略，主要因为外形。它不是笔直往上走，而是整栋楼随着高度扭转，外面包着两层玻璃，所以表面看起来有点像一条飘带。白天它反射当天的天气，天黑之后楼上的灯光会变色，所以你每次经过看到的都不一样。

用途方面，它不是单纯的写字楼，而是综合性的。下面一段是商铺和餐厅，中间是办公区，再往上是酒店。靠近顶部有个观光层，这也是大多数游客真正来的目的，因为天气好的时候能一直看到江对岸去。

我算是喜欢它，不过更多是把它当成一件设计作品，而不是一个想待的地方。让我佩服的是，这么高的一栋楼居然能做得优雅而不是笨重，这不容易。我唯一的保留意见跟它代表的东西有关，因为这种量级的建筑往往更多体现一座城市的野心，而不是住在里面的人。

Part3 讨论题

01 Have you ever lived in a high-rise building?

Yes, I have, for most of my adult life. The flat I rent now is on the eighteenth floor of a residential block. The main advantage is the light and the quiet, since you're well above the traffic. The main drawback is that when a lift breaks down, as it did twice last year, getting home turns into a serious workout.

住过，成年后大部分时间都住在高楼里。我现在租的房子在一栋居民楼的十八层。最大的好处是采光和安静，因为离马路很远。最大的问题是电梯坏了的时候 —— 去年坏过两次 —— 回家就成了一场硬仗。

02 What impact do you think climate has on architectural design?

Quite a significant one, and I think that's only going to grow. In hot climates the design has to deal with sunlight and cooling, which is why you see deep balconies and thick walls in traditional buildings there. In colder places the priority is keeping heat in. More recently, architects have been thinking about extreme weather as well, so

drainage, wind resistance and shade are built in from the start rather than added later.

影响相当大，而且我觉得只会越来越大。炎热气候下设计必须处理日晒和降温，这就是为什么那些地方的传统建筑常见深阳台和厚墙。寒冷地区则优先考虑保温。近些年建筑师还要考虑极端天气，所以排水、抗风和遮阳都是从一开始就设计进去，而不是后来再补。

03 Why do you think many Chinese people now live in high-rise buildings?

Mostly because of how much land there is relative to the number of people. In large cities, building upwards is the only realistic way to house everyone reasonably close to where the jobs are. There's a practical side to it as well, since a modern tower usually comes with a lift, heating and a management office, all of which are more convenient than an old low-rise block.

主要是人多地少。在大城市里，想让大家住得离工作不算太远，往上建几乎是唯一现实的办法。另外还有很实际的层面：新式高楼通常配电梯、供暖和物业，这些都比老旧的低层楼房方便。

04 In the future, will Chinese people prefer high-rise buildings or houses?

For city dwellers I think towers will stay dominant, simply because

the space problem isn't going away. But I wouldn't be surprised to see more people move to low-rise housing on the edges of cities or in smaller towns, especially now that remote work is more common. So it may end up being less a matter of preference than of where people can afford to live.

对城市居民来说，我估计高楼仍会是主流，因为空间问题不会消失。但我觉得会有更多人搬到城市边缘或小城市的低层住宅，尤其现在远程办公更普遍了。所以到最后，这可能不是一个偏好问题，而是人们住得起哪儿的问题。

05 Why do you think some people design their own homes?

Usually because what's available on the market doesn't match how they actually live. Anyone who has looked at flats knows how many have a layout that makes no sense for their household, whether it's a tiny kitchen or a room with no window. Designing your own place also lets you control the details, and for some people the process itself is part of the pleasure.

通常是因为市面上的房子和他们的实际生活对不上。看过房的人都知道，很多户型对自己家来说完全不合理，要么厨房小得可怜，要么有间房没窗。自己设计还能把细节握在手里，而且对有些人来说，这个过程本身就是乐趣的一部分。

03 本地新闻

Describe local news you have heard or seen

You should say:

What it was

When you heard or saw it

Where you heard or saw it

And explain how you felt about it.

示范作答 The local news I'd like to talk about is a story I saw about the old food market in my district being rebuilt. I came across it about three months ago on a local news account I follow, and then read a longer article about it on the city newspaper's website.The story was that the market, which had been there for over forty years, was going to close for six months and reopen with better drainage, wider aisles and a proper ventilation system. The vendors were going to be moved to a temporary site nearby in the meantime. The report also mentioned that the rent for the stalls would stay roughly the same, which had apparently been the main worry for everybody involved.

I felt genuinely pleased when I read it, and slightly surprised. That market is where my grandmother did her shopping for decades, and I remember it being cramped and rather unpleasant, especially in

summer. I had assumed it would eventually just be knocked down and replaced by something expensive.

What struck me most about the story was how many comments it got. People were arguing about whether the renovation would make it too clean and strip out the character, which I thought was a fair point. Even so, I think it's a good thing, because a market that people actually use is worth looking after. It left me feeling more positive about how the city is being managed.

我想说的这条本地新闻，是关于我们区那个老菜市场要改建的消息。大概三个月前，我在关注的一个本地新闻号上看到的，之后又在市报网站上读了一篇更长的报道。内容是：这个开了四十多年的市场要关闭六个月，重新开放后会改善排水、加宽过道，并装上正规的通风系统。这期间摊贩会被安置到附近一个临时场地。报道里还提到摊位租金大体不变 —— 这显然正是所有相关的人最关心的问题。

看完之后我挺高兴，也有点意外。那个市场是我奶奶买了几十年菜的地方，我记得里面很拥挤，夏天尤其难受。我原本以为它迟早会被拆掉，然后换成什么贵的东西。

让我印象最深的是这条新闻下面评论特别多。大家在争论改造之后会不会太干净、把原来的味道弄没了，我觉得这话有道理。即便这样，我还是认为这是好事，因为一个大家真的在用的市场，值得被好好维

护。它让我对这座城市的管理更有信心了一点。

Part3 讨论题

01 Do many people talk about local news?

Not as much as you'd expect, in my experience. People follow anything dramatic, like a fire or a road closure, but routine council decisions tend to pass unnoticed. I think that's partly because local coverage is scattered across small accounts, so there's no single obvious place to look.

据我观察，没有想象中那么多。碰上火灾、封路这类大事大家都会关注，但日常的市政决定基本没人注意。我觉得一部分原因是本地报道分散在很多小账号上，没有一个明显集中的地方可看。

02 Do young people or old people care more about local news?

Older people, generally. They tend to have lived in the same area for much longer, so they know the streets, the shops and the people involved, which makes the news mean something to them. Younger people often move between districts or cities for work, so they have less reason to follow what happens in one particular neighbourhood.

整体上年纪大的人更关心。他们往往在一个地方住得久得多，认识那些街道、店铺和相关的人，所以新闻对他们来说有具体意义。年轻人常为工作在区与区、城与城之间搬，因此关注某个特定社区的理由就

少一些。

03 Do people pay more attention to local news or national news?

National news, by a wide margin, mainly because it's everywhere. It arrives through push notifications and social media feeds whether you look for it or not. Local news requires you to go and find it, so it only gets attention from the people who have a specific reason to care.

全国新闻，差距很大，主要因为它无处不在。不管你找不找它，推送和社交信息流里都会出现。本地新闻需要你主动去找，所以只有那些有具体理由关心的人才会去看。

04 医疗行业从业者

Describe a person you know who works in the medical field (e.g. doctor, nurse, vet)

You should say:

Who this person is

How you know him or her

What he or she does in their job

And explain how you feel about him or her

示范作答 **The person I'd like to describe is a vet called Zhou Wei, who runs a small animal clinic in the neighbourhood where I grew up. I've known him since I was about ten, when we took our family cat to**

him for the first time.He qualified as a doctor for humans first, and spent about three years working in a hospital before he switched. He told me once that he found the pace and the paperwork exhausting, and that he'd wanted to work with animals since he was a child. So he retrained, which took another few years, and eventually opened his own practice.

These days his work is a mixture of the ordinary and the difficult. A lot of it is routine: vaccinations, check- ups, dental work and neutering. But he also handles emergencies, including surgery, and he does house calls for farmers in the villages outside the city who can't easily bring a sick animal in. He's on call most weekends, which I don't think I could manage.

What I feel about him is a lot of respect, and a bit of guilt, because I once took a stray kitten to him and never paid the full bill. He didn't chase me for it and just told me to bring the cat back for its injections. To me that's what makes him well suited to his job. He isn't sentimental about animals, but he takes the responsibility seriously, and he always explains things to owners in plain language instead of trying to sound clever.

我想说的这个人是周伟，一位兽医，在我从小长大的那片开了间小动物诊所。我大概十岁认识他的，那年我们第一次带家里的猫去看病。

他原本学的是给人看病的临床医学，在医院干了三年左右才转的方向。他有一次跟我说，他受不了那种节奏和文书工作，而且从小就特别想跟动物打交道。于是他重新去读，又花了几年时间，最后自己开了诊所。

现在他的工作一半是平常事，一半是难事。很多是常规的：打疫苗、体检、洗牙、绝育。但他也接急诊，包括做手术，还会上门去给城外村里的养殖户看诊 —— 那些人把生病的动物送进城不容易。他大多数周末都得待命，这点我自己肯定做不到。

我对他主要是敬佩，还有一点愧疚，因为有一次我把捡来的一只小猫送过去，最后并没付清全部费用。他没有追着我要，只是让我记得带猫回来打针。在我看来，这恰恰说明他适合这份工作。他对动物谈不上多愁善感，但会认真负责任，而且给主人解释情况时总说大白话，而不是故意讲得高深。

Part3 讨论题

01 Why do some people want to be doctors?

I think it's a mixture of motivations, and they aren't all noble. Some people are genuinely drawn to helping others, and medicine offers that in a very direct way. Others are attracted by the security and the respect that come with the profession, and in many families there's also pressure to choose something obviously respectable.

我觉得动机是混杂的，并不都那么高尚。有些人确实是被帮助他人吸引，而医学提供了一个非常直接的途径。另一些人看中的是这个职业带来的稳定和尊重，而且很多家庭里也有压力，要选一个显而易见体面的行当。

02 Do you think it is difficult to become a doctor?

Extremely, and the difficulty isn't only academic. Getting in requires very high exam results, then the training takes years longer than most degrees, and much of it is done while you're already exhausted. What makes it harder still is that there's no point at which you can stop, because medicine keeps changing and you're expected to keep studying throughout your career.

非常难，而且难的不只是学业。入学要求分数很高，培养时间比大多数专业长好几年，而且很多训练是在你已经精疲力尽的情况下完成的。更难的一点是它没有终点，因为医学一直在变，你整个职业生涯都得不断学习。

03 Do you think studying biology at school makes students healthier?

Not on its own. Knowing how the body works makes it easier to understand why certain habits matter, and I think that's genuinely valuable. But the gap between knowing and doing is wide, especially for teenagers, who are influenced far more by their friends and their

mood than by a textbook. So I'd call it a useful foundation rather than a solution.

单靠它不行。了解身体怎么运作，能让人更容易明白某些习惯为什么重要，我觉得这确实有价值。但从知道到做到之间距离很大，尤其对青少年来说，影响他们更多的是朋友和心情，而不是课本。所以我会说它是个有用的基础，而不是解决办法。

05 商业人物

Describe a business person you admire

You should say:

Who this person is

How you know him or her

What business he or she does

And explain why you admire him or her

示范作答 **The business person I admire is Wang Chuanfu, who founded BYD. I know about him mainly from business journalism and from a long interview I watched a couple of years ago, though his name is hard to avoid now that the company sells so many electric cars.He started out as a researcher in a state institute working on batteries, and set up his own company in the mid- nineties in Shenzhen with a small group of people. At that time the market for rechargeable batteries was dominated by Japanese firms and hardly**

anyone believed a new Chinese company could compete. He got around part of the problem by automating as little as possible and using workers where machines were too expensive, which was unusual, and rather unfashionable, at the time.

What he did next is the part I find most interesting. He moved from batteries into making cars, and then into building the batteries, the motors and even the software himself rather than buying them in. Most car companies work the other way round. That decision looked reckless to a lot of analysts, and for years BYD was treated as something of a joke in the industry.

I admire him because of the patience that required. He kept investing in a direction he believed in while almost everyone told him it wouldn't work, and it took well over a decade to pay off. I'm also struck by the fact that he still describes himself as an engineer rather than a businessman, and he's known for living fairly simply. That combination of stubbornness and modesty is rare in people who build companies that big.

我敬佩的企业家是王传福，比亚迪的创始人。我对他的了解主要来自商业报道，还有几年前看过的一段长访谈。不过现在他公司的电动车卖得那么多，这个名字也很难避开了。他最早是国有研究所里做电池的研究人员，九十年代中期在深圳带着一小批人出来自己办公司。那

时候充电电池市场基本被日本企业占着，几乎没人相信一家中国新公司能竞争得过。他的部分解法是尽量少用自动化，在机器太贵的地方改用人，这个做法当时并不常见，甚至有点不合潮流。

接下来这一步是我觉得最有意思的。他从电池跨到造车，然后又自己去做电池、电机甚至软件，而不是从外面买。大多数车企走的是相反的路。这个决定在很多分析师看来像是蛮干，比亚迪有几年在业内是被当成笑话看的。

我敬佩他正是因为这件事所需要的耐心。在几乎所有人都说行不通的时候，他仍然往自己相信的方向持续投钱，而这件事花了十多年才见回报。另外让我触动的是，他至今仍把自己称作工程师而不是商人，生活上也以简朴出名。把公司做到那么大的人里，这种固执加谦逊的组合很少见。

06 特殊场合的食物

Describe a special meal or food you eat on a particular occasion

You should say:

What it is

How it is made

When and where you eat it

And explain why you eat it

示范作答 **The food I'd like to describe is a dish we always make for**

the Spring Festival, a kind of steamed dumpling with a sweet filling.It isn't complicated, but it takes time. You start with glutinous rice flour and add water gradually until it forms a soft dough, which then has to rest for a while. The filling is usually crushed peanuts mixed with sugar and a little lard, though my grandmother used to add dried osmanthus to hers. You take a small piece of dough, flatten it in your palm, put a spoonful of filling in the middle, and then close it up and roll it into a ball. They're steamed for about fifteen minutes and eaten warm, sometimes with a little syrup poured over them.

We eat them on the first morning of the new year, before anyone goes out of the house, and then again when relatives come round during the following week. My grandmother made them every year without fail, and now my mother and my aunt take turns. Nobody in my generation has properly learned how to do it, which is something everyone keeps pointing out.

The reason we eat them is partly tradition and partly the symbolism behind it. The round shape stands for the family being complete and together, and the sweetness is a wish that the year ahead will be a good one. I eat them mainly because of that feeling of continuity. Honestly, I find them a bit too sweet, but I've never once turned them down.

我想说的这道东西，是我们过年一定会做的一种甜馅蒸团子。做法不复杂，但费时间。先用糯米粉，一点点加水揉成软面团，然后让它醒一会儿。馅一般是花生碎加白糖和一点猪油，不过我奶奶会往里面加干桂花。取一小块面团，在手心里按扁，中间放一勺馅，再收口搓圆。上锅蒸十五分钟左右，趁热吃，有时会再淋一点糖浆。

我们在新年的第一个早上吃，得在谁出门之前吃完；接下来一周里亲戚来串门时也会做。以前每年都是我奶奶做，从来没落下过；现在是我妈和姑姑轮流。我们这一辈没一个正经学会的，这一点大家都要拿来说。

吃它的原因，一半是传统，一半是寓意。圆形代表一家人齐齐整整，甜是希望新的一年顺顺当当。我吃它主要是为了这种延续感。说实话我觉得有点太甜了，但我一次也没拒绝过。

07 观看体育比赛

Describe an experience of watching a sports event

You should say:

What the event was

When and where you watched it

Who you watched it with

And explain how you felt about this experience

示范作答 **The event I want to describe is a women's volleyball match**

I watched at a stadium in Nanjing about two years ago. It was a league game rather than an international one, but the hall was still nearly full.I went with a friend from university whose family had spare tickets, so it wasn't something I had planned. We got there about half an hour early, which turned out to be a good decision, because by the time the players came out to warm up the atmosphere was already building.

What struck me first was how loud it was. There was a drum section at one end of the hall, and whenever the home team served, the whole crowd went quiet almost on its own, which I hadn't expected at all. The rallies were much longer than they look on television, and you could hear the ball being hit and the players calling to each other, all of which a broadcast completely loses.

The match went to five sets, so we were there for well over two hours. The home team lost the final set narrowly, and the way the crowd reacted is the part I remember most clearly. Nobody left immediately; people just stood there and clapped for a couple of minutes.

I came away enjoying it far more than I thought I would. I'd only ever watched volleyball on a screen before, and being there made me realise that the appeal isn't really the result. It's the sense of a lot of people caring about the same thing at the same moment, which is

hard to get from television.

我想说的这场比赛，是大约两年前在南京一个体育馆里看的女子排球联赛。是俱乐部之间的比赛，不是国际赛，但场馆照样坐得满满当当。我是和一个大学同学一起去的，他家里有多余的票，所以这件事并不在我计划之内。我们提前半小时到了，事后看这是对的，因为球员出来热身的时候，气氛就已经起来了。

最先让我意外的是声音有多大。场馆一头有一片打鼓的观众，主队发球的时候，全场几乎是自动就安静下来，这点我完全没想到。回合也比电视上看着长得多，能听见击球的声音、队员之间互相喊话，这些转播里是全丢掉的。

比赛打满五局，我们在那儿待了两个多小时。主队最后一局惜败，而观众的反应是我记得最清楚的部分。没有人立刻走，大家就站在那儿鼓了几分钟掌。

出来的时候我发现自己比预想的享受得多。以前我只在屏幕上看过排球，到现场才明白，它的吸引力其实不在结果，而在于很多人同一时刻在意同一件事 —— 这种感觉从电视里很难得到。

08 改变决定

Describe a time when you changed a decision

You should say:

What decision you made

Why you changed the decisionIs it a good result

And explain how you felt about it

示范作答 The decision I want to talk about is one I changed last year, when I was choosing between two job offers.The first offer came from a company in another city. It paid noticeably more and the role sounded more impressive on paper, so I accepted it fairly quickly, almost without thinking. I had already started looking at flats there and told my family I was moving.

What made me change my mind was a conversation with someone who had done that job for three years. She was honest with me and described what the week actually looked like: leaving on Sunday evening, getting back on Friday night, living out of a suitcase, and spending most of the time in hotels. She also mentioned that several people in her team had left within a year.

So a week before I was supposed to sign the contract, I withdrew. The other offer was in my own city, paid less, and was a less glamorous position. I took that one instead.

Was it a good result? On balance, yes, though I won't pretend it was straightforward. For the first few months I kept wondering whether I had been too cautious, especially when I saw what my classmates from university were earning. But I've been able to keep up my

running, see my family regularly, and I don't dread Sunday evenings, which I think counts for a great deal.

How I felt about it was mainly relief, mixed with a bit of embarrassment at having made such a public decision and then reversed it. What I took from the whole thing is that I shouldn't accept something simply because it looks good from the outside.

我想说的这个决定是去年改的，当时我正在两份工作之间做选择。第一份来自另一个城市的一家公司。薪水明显更高，职位写在纸上也更体面，所以我很快就答应了，几乎没怎么想。我当时已经在那儿看房子，也跟家里说了要搬过去。

让我改主意的是和一个人的一次聊天。她做那份工作做了三年。她很坦诚，把一周的真实样子讲给我听：周日晚出发，周五晚上回来，一直活在行李箱里，大部分时间在酒店。她还提到，她团队里有好几个人不到一年就走了。

所以在原本要签合同的一周前，我退出了。另一份工作在我自己的城市，钱少一些，职位也没那么光鲜。我选了那个。

结果算好吗？总体上是好的，但我不想假装这个过程很轻松。头几个月我一直在想自己是不是太保守了，尤其是看到大学同学的收入时。不过我现在还能坚持跑步，能常常见到家人，而且我不再害怕周日的晚上 —— 我觉得这一点很值。

我的感受主要是松了一口气，另外还有点难为情，因为那个决定做得很公开，结果又反悔了。这件事让我明白了一点：不该仅仅因为一样东西从外面看着好就接受它。

09 长期目标

Describe an ambition you have had for a long time

You should say:

What it was

How you got the desire to want to achieve it

What you have to do to achieve it

And explain how you feel about it

示范作答 **The ambition I've had for a long time is to be able to read a novel in a foreign language without looking anything up. I know that sounds modest, but for me it's the clearest sign that I've actually learned a language rather than just studied it.I think the desire came from one specific moment. When I was about sixteen, I tried to read a book in English that a friend had recommended, and I gave up after three pages. It was frustrating in a way that stayed with me, and I decided then that I wanted to get to the point where that wouldn't happen.**

To get there I've had to do a few things fairly consistently.

长久以来，我一直有个心愿：能够通读一本外文小说，全程不用查阅任何生词。我知道这个目标听起来不算宏大，但对我而言，这才是真正掌握一门语言最明确的标志 —— 不只是单纯学习过这门语言，而是学会运用它。

这份向往源于一个特别的瞬间。大概十六岁那年，我试着读朋友推荐的一本英文书，结果只读了三页就放弃了。那种挫败感久久萦绕在心头，也就是在那时，我下定决心，一定要达到不再出现这种窘境的水平。

为了实现这个目标，我坚持踏踏实实地做了几件事。

10 科技产品故障

Describe a problem of technology you have encountered, like a computer or a cell phone.

You should say:

What it was

When and where you had this problem

How the problem was solved

And explain how you felt when you had this problem

示范作答 The problem I want to talk about happened about eight months ago, when my phone stopped charging properly.

It started gradually. The cable would connect, the battery icon would appear for a second, and then the charging would stop. I assumed the cable was worn out, so I bought a new one, and it worked for a couple of days before the same thing happened. Then I tried a completely different charger and got the same result, which was when I started to suspect the fault was in the phone itself.

It couldn't have come at a worse time either. I was two days away from a trip and had most of my tickets and hotel bookings stored on the phone, so I ended up writing everything down on paper, which felt ridiculous in this day and age.

The problem turned out to be the charging port rather than the battery. I took it to a repair shop near the technician showed me that a small amount of dust and lint had collected inside and compacted, so the cable wasn't seating properly. He cleaned it out with a thin brush and a bit of compressed air, which took about ten minutes, and charged me almost nothing. He also told me to stop keeping the phone in my trouser pocket, since that's where the dust comes from.

How I felt during those few days was genuinely anxious, more so than the situation really deserved. What struck me was how completely useless the phone became without a working charger, because everything from payments to directions depends on it. It did make me clear out some old files and start carrying a bit of cash again, at least for a while.
我想说的这件事发生在大约八个月前，我的手机开始充不进去电。

它是慢慢变严重的。插上线，电池图标闪一下，然后就不充了。我以为是线老化了，就买了根新的，用了两天又 是同样的毛病。后来我换了一个完全不同的充电器，结果一样——这时候我开始怀疑问题在手机本身。

而且时机糟糕得不能再糟糕。再过两天我就要出门旅行，机票和酒店订单基本都存在手机里，最后我只能全部写 在纸上，在现在这个年代显得特别荒唐。

问题最后查出来在充电口，不是电池。我拿到公司附近一家维修店，师傅给我看：里面进了一小撮灰尘和毛絮， 被压得很实，所以插头根本插不到位。他用细刷子和一点压缩空气清出来，前后不到十分钟，几乎没收我钱。他还让我别再往裤兜里放手机，说灰就是从那儿进去的。

那几天我的感受是真焦虑，比事情的严重程度要夸张。让我印象最深的是，充电器一坏，手机就彻底没用了—— 从付款到导航全靠它。这件事确实让我清掉了些旧文件，也开始随身带一点现金，至少维持了一阵子。

11 必须早起

Describe a time when you had to get up very early

You should say:

Where you were

What time you had to get up

Why you had to get up so early

And explain how you felt about getting up very early

示范作答 The time I had to get up very early was last spring, when I had a flight that left at about six in the morning.

I was at home, so that meant setting an alarm for half past three, which is a time I'd rather not seefrom that side. Because the airport is on the far side of the city, I'd worked out that I needed to leave by four, which meant everything had to be ready the night before. I remember packing, laying out my clothes, and then lying awake worrying that I would somehow sleep through the alarm anyway.

The reason for taking such an early flight was simply that it was much cheaper. It was around half the price of the mid-morning one, and I had convinced myself at the time that the saving was worth it. In hindsight, that calculation left out how much the following day would cost me in energy.

How I felt about it was mostly irritated, in a fairly childish way. The taxi ride was fine and the roads were completely empty, which was the one genuine advantage. But I couldn't sleep on the plane, and I spent the whole afternoon in a daze and ended up going to bed at eight in the evening, which then threw off the next couple of days as well.

So the honest conclusion is that I'd rather pay more next time. I've since decided that I'll accept an inconvenient early start for something I actually want to do, like catching a train for a trip I'm looking forward to, but not simply to save money on a flight.

我被迫起得特别早的那次是去年春天，我有一班早上六点左右的飞机。

当时我在家里，所以闹钟得定在三点半——这个时间点我情愿不要从这个方向看到。因为机场在城市另一头，我算下来四点就得出门，也就是说所有事情都得头天晚上弄好。我记得收完行李、把衣服摆好，

然后躺在床上清醒着，担心自己不管怎样都会睡过头。

选这么早的航班，原因很简单：便宜。价格大概是上午那班的一半，我当时说服自己这点省下的钱是值的。事后想想，这个算法里漏掉了一整天的精力成本。我的感受主要是烦躁，而且挺幼稚的那种。打车倒是顺利，路上空得没有一辆车，这是唯一实实在在的好处。但我在飞机上睡不着，整个下午都昏昏沉沉，最后晚上八点就躺下了，接着又把后两天也搞乱了。

所以老实说的结论是：下次我宁可多花钱。我后来想明白了，如果是我真心想做的事——比如赶一趟期待已久的旅行的火车——我愿意接受不方便的早起；但单纯为了省机票钱，不会了。

12 不想住的房子

Describe a home that you like to visit but did not want to live in

You should say:

Where it is

What it is like

What you visited it for

And explain why you would not like to live there

示范作答 The home I'd like to describe is my uncle's house, in

a village about an hour outside the city.

It's a two-storey house with a courtyard at the front and a small vegetable plot behind it. The walls are brick with a tiled roof, and there's a large tree near the gate that shades most of the yard in summer. Inside, the rooms are generous by city standards, with high ceilings and a thick stone floor that stays cool even in August.

We visit mostly during holidays and at the Spring Festival, and the reason is always the same: to see my uncle and aunt, and to eat properly. My aunt cooks on a wood stove, and everything comes from the plot or from the neighbours, which makes a real difference to how it tastes. I usually stay for two or three nights, and I always sleep better there than I do at home.

So why wouldn't I want to live there? A few honest reasons. The nearest hospital and the nearest supermarket are both about half an hour away by car, and there's no bus, so anything unplanned becomes a genuine hassle. The internet is slow enough that I can't work from there, and the mobile signal drops in

some of the rooms. In winter the house is cold in a way that extra heating doesn't really fix, because the building was never designed for it.

I like it precisely because it's a place I go to rather than a place I have to manage. It's restful partly because I'm only there briefly. If it were my everyday home, I suspect I'd spend most of my time worrying about the practical problems, and the charm would wear off fairly quickly.
我想说的这个房子是我叔叔家，在一个离城大概一小时车程的村子里。

是一栋两层的房子，前面有个院子，后面一小块菜地。砖墙配瓦顶，门口一棵大树，夏天能遮住大半个院子。屋里的房间按城里标准算宽敞，层高很高，铺的是厚石板，八月里还是凉的。我们一般是假期和春节去，理由永远一样：看叔叔婶婶，还有好好吃几顿。婶婶用土灶做饭，东西不是自家地里长的就是邻居给的，味道确实不一样。我通常住两三个晚上，在那儿睡得比我家里好。

那我为什么不想住在那儿？有几个实在的理由。最近的医院和超市开车都得半小时，而且没有公交，所以任何计划外的事都特别麻烦。网慢得我在那儿没法工作，有些房间手机信号还断。冬天屋里那种冷，

再多烧点暖气也解决不了，因为这房子本来就不是为这个设计的。

我喜欢它，恰恰因为它是我去的地方，而不是我得操心的地方。它让人放松，一部分原因就是我待得短。如果那是我每天的家，我估计大部分时间都在担心各种实际问题，那种好感觉很快就会消磨掉。

13 名人广告

Describe a piece of advertisement which is about a famous person

You should say:

What the advertisement is about

When and where you saw it

What the famous person does in the advertisement

And explain how you felt about it

示范作答 The advertisement I'd like to describe is a campaign for a sports drink, which featured a well-known badminton player.

I saw it about a year ago, mostly online but also on television during a tournament, so I must have come across it dozens of times over a few weeks. It was shot in a training hall, and

it opens with the player alone, practising one particular shot over and over against a wall, with the sound of the shuttle hitting the wall and nothing else. There's no music at all for the first thirty seconds.

In the advertisement itself, the famous person doesn't actually do anything dramatic. She misses a lot of shots early on, and there's no moment where she turns to the camera or says a line. About two thirds of the way through, the hall fills up with children arriving for training and the music finally starts. The closing shot is just her picking a shuttle up off the floor, which I thought was a well-chosen ending.

How I felt about it was, first, slightly surprised, because most sports advertising is loud and fast and this one deliberately wasn't. It also felt more honest than the usual campaign, since it shows failure before success rather than pretending the whole thing is effortless, and that's closer to what training is actually like. And I noticed that I could remember the brand afterwards, which presumably was the entire point.

So I'd say it worked on me in the sense that I didn't skip it. Whether it made me buy the drink is a different question, and the answer is no, but I did watch it properly several times, which is more than I can say for almost any other advertisement.
我想说的这条广告是一个运动饮料的推广，主角是一位很有名的羽毛球运动员。

我是大约一年前看到的，主要在网络上，比赛期间电视里也播，所以那几周里我大概碰到过几十次。片子是在一个训练馆里拍的，开头只有她一个人，对着墙反复练同一个球，除了球撞墙的声音什么都没有。前三十秒完全没有配乐。

广告里这位名人其实没做什么戏剧性的事。她开头失误了很多次，也没有哪一刻转头对着镜头说话。到大约三分之二的地方，训练馆里陆续进来一群来训练的小孩，音乐这时候才起来。最后一个镜头就是她弯腰从地上捡起一个球——我觉得这个收尾选得挺好的。

我的感受是，先有点意外。因为大部分运动广告都又吵又快，而这条故意反着来。它也比一般的广告更诚实，先拍失败再拍成功，而不是装作一切都很轻松，这更接近训练的真实样子。另外我发现看完之后我能记住这个牌子——这大概本来就是目的。

所以我觉得它在我这儿算是成功的，至少我没有划掉它。至于它有没有让我去买那瓶饮料，那是另一个问题，答案是没有；但我确实认真看了好几遍，这一点几乎任何别的广告都做不到。

14 语言高手

Describe a person who is good at learning languages

You should say:

Who it is

How you knew him or her

What languages he or she has learnt

And explain why you think he or she is good at learning languages

示范作答

The person I'd like to describe is a former colleague called Lin, who I think speaks five languages to a genuinely useful level.

I got to know her at work, where we shared an office for about two years. I remember being confused during my first week, because I couldn't tell which language was her first one, since she switched between them so easily within the same

conversation.

As far as I know, she grew up speaking Mandarin and a regional dialect at home, learned English at school, and then took up Japanese at university. After that she added Spanish and, more recently, Korean, which she started mainly because she wanted to watch things without subtitles. She isn't equally fluent in all five, and she'd be the first to say so, but she can hold a real conversation in each of them.

What makes her good at it, I think, is not any special talent but her tolerance for being bad at things. She'll start speaking a language from the first week, making mistakes constantly and not being remotely embarrassed about it, whereas most people wait until they feel ready. She also has a habit of learning through things she'd enjoy anyway, like songs or dramas, so the practice never really feels like study.

I'd add that she's unusually good at listening rather than just producing sentences. She picks up accents quickly and can usually guess which region someone is from. Watching her, I've

come to think that the main barrier for most people isn't ability at all, but the willingness to sound foolish for a while.

我想说的这个人是林，我以前的同事。我觉得她有五门语言是能真正用起来的水平。

我是在工作时认识她的，我们在一个办公室共事了大概两年。我记得第一周我很困惑，因为我搞不清她的母语是哪一种——她在同一段对话里切换得太自然了。

据我所知，她从小在家里说普通话和一种方言，在学校学的英语，大学又学了日语。之后她又学了西班牙语，最近还加上了韩语，学韩语的起因主要是想不看字幕看剧。这五门她的水平并不一致，她自己也会第一个承认，但每一门都能正常交流。

我觉得她厉害的地方不在天赋，而在于她能忍受自己做得差。任何一门语言她从第一周就开口说，不停犯错，一点也不觉得难为情；而大多数人会等到「准备好了」再开口。她还有个习惯，就是通过自己本来就会享受的东西去学——比如歌、剧——所以练习感觉不像在学习。

我还想加上一点：她不只会造句，听的能力也特别好。她能很快抓住口音，通常能猜出对方是哪个地方的人。观察她之后，我渐渐认为，

对大多数人来说，学习语言最大的障碍根本不是天赋能力，而是愿意在一段时间里不怕开口出丑、敢于犯错。